

Who's next: Sunil Chhetri has been the leader of the Indian attack for years. The time has now come to find an able successor. AIFF MEDIA

With Sunil Chhetri — India's leading goalscorer and the regular striker for the national team — having his playing days numbered at 39 years of age, it becomes imperative to find his replacement sooner rather than later.

This is not to say that teams without strikers have never succeeded before. Pep Guardiola did wonders with Barcelona and Manchester City in club football, winning league titles with both sides.

But this structure is hard to replicate in international football, where coaches get their players for a limited time in the national camp and depend primarily on strikers for goals.

So has been the case with India, which has had strikers like Mohammed Rafi, Jeje Lalpekhlua, Robin Singh and Chhetri over the past decade.

Under the previous coach, Stephen Constantine, the Blue Tigers had taken the long-ball approach, playing with a typical British formation of 4-4-2.

Players such as Anirudh Thapa, Pranoy Halder and Eugeneson Lyngdoh delivered floated balls from the midfield, which were then handled by the strikers.

The strategy seemed to have worked well during Constantine's second stint (2015-2019), as the team scored 72 goals in 42 matches, winning 23 of them. It also won the 2015 SAFF Championship and the 2018 Intercontinental Cup.

India also performed relatively better at the Asian Cup during this period compared to the 2023 edition, winning one game (4-1 against Thailand) with a three-goal margin.

Under Stimac though, the team shifted to a more modern approach, adopting a 4-2-3-1 shape for most of its games. The build-up of play in this case started at the back, with more dependency on crosses and set-pieces to find a breakthrough.

In both cases, however, the

striker's role as the head of the attack has been paramount. But game-time for Indian strikers in the top division has been very low as compared to that of foreign forwards.

ISL teams have started Indians as one or both strikers in about one-fourth of their games this season (62 of 234 – total games are 117 and two teams in each game gives a sample size of 234 considering each team's matches individually).

That falls to one-fifth (46) if Chhetri is taken out of the equation. On the contrary, foreign players have started as strikers in over half of the matches (172) in the league.

What makes a striker a proven marksman?

The clubs have a penchant for using experienced foreign strikers because they score more goals and that, in turn, goes a long way in helping teams win matches and titles — the *raison d'être* of playing a football match in the first place.

"Many coaches (in ISL) have the tendency of not preferring Indian forwards because of some fake pressure to find results. Most of the teams sign foreign strikers for that," Ivan Vukomanovic, the head coach of Kerala Blasters, had told reporters on ISL media day last year.

"And because of this fake pressure, most of the coaches are not allowing Indian forwards with good profiles enough minutes on the ground."

In a 4-3-3 formation or a three-man forward line, the player in the middle is the centre-forward (CF). But in a two-man forward line — as seen in formations such as 4-4-2, 5-3-2 and 3-5-2 — or a

single-man-in-the-front shape (4-2-3-1 and 4-1-4-1), the players in the front are termed as strikers (ST).

In two-man forward lines, one player plays as a secondary striker (SS) and the other is the ST.

This ISL season, 62 players have started as a CF or a ST, of which only 23 are Indians, while 39 are foreigners.

Among the top 20 players who have started as a CF or ST and have completed the full 90 minutes, there are only two Indians — Chhetri (eight matches) and Lallianzualla Chhangte (three matches).

These two already play in the Indian national team. But the problem seems more acute when you consider that one of them is 39.

In the last two editions, one factor was common for the ISL playoff winning sides — a foreign striker who finished top of the scoring charts.

In 2022, it was Bartholomew Ogbeche (Nigeria) of Hyderabad FC and the last edition saw Australian Dimitri Petratos of ATK Mohun Bagan (now known as Mohun Bagan Super Giant) led their respective clubs to trophies.

In a decade of ISL, there have been no Indian Golden Boot winners. Even before that, the I-League — India's former top division — had foreigners as the highest goalscorers, except for Chhetri in the 2013-14 season.

The I-League was dominated by two Nigerians, Ranti Martins (5 Golden Boots) and Odafe Onyeka Okolie (3 Golden Boots), while the ISL has had Brazilians (Elano, Marcelinho, Diego Mauricio, Cleiton Silva) and Spaniards (Coro, Angulo) leading the table.

« We need to allow young boys to start playing as a centre-forward for us, in the lower leagues, then the ISL and hopefully, in foreign clubs someday. And then hope that someone like Sunil Chhetri will appear to represent the country. But unless people start working seriously on a long-term plan, nothing will happen — Igor Stimac, head coach of the Indian men's football team »